Eftsure Observability CTF Brief

A hands-on hunt through Grafana Cloud — find the hidden flags

Welcome

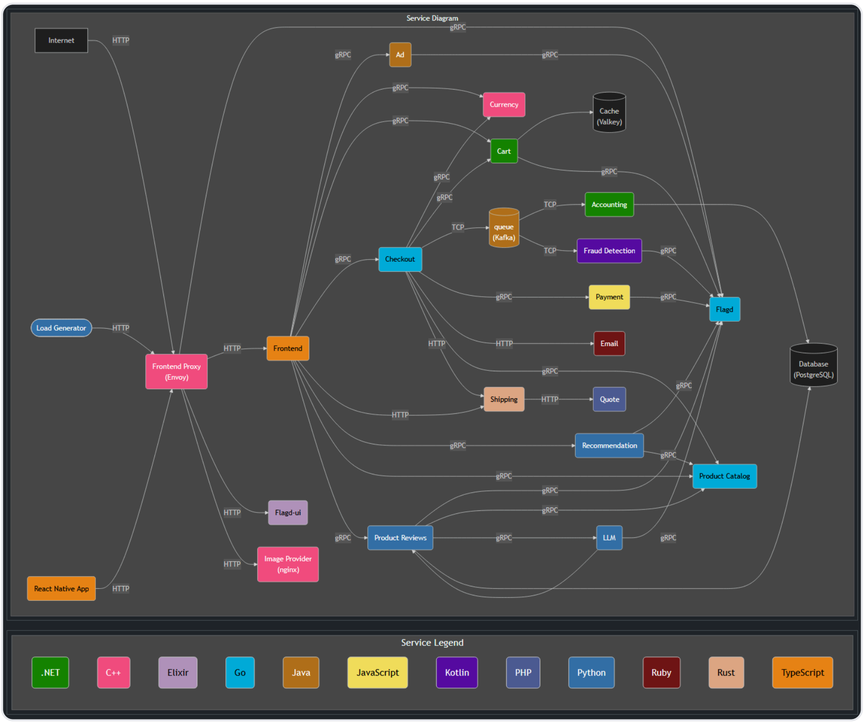
This is a hands-on **capture-the-flag** to get you comfortable with **Grafana Cloud**. We've injected real-looking failures into a live "Astronomy Shop" microservices demo. When an issue is triggered, a hidden **flag** (a secret string) shows up somewhere in the telemetry that issue produces. Your job: find it in Grafana and send it in. Learn the platform, and have some fun doing it.

This will be a **competition** played in **teams of 2–3**, see the **FAQ** for details.

The system

Grafana Cloud: https://hackathon.grafana.net. It's the Grafana Cloud instance holding all of the demo's telemetry — logs, metrics and traces — and all the other supporting features. Every flag is found somewhere in here.

The telemetry comes from a microservices demo, an online astronomy store. You can browse the running app itself at http://grafana-hackathon.in.eftsure.com.



> ⚠️ **Note:** *Kafka (queue), Accounting, and Fraud Detection* appear in the standard demo diagram but are **not running** for this event — they emit no telemetry, so don't go looking there.

A full list of services with short descriptions — and which ones could surface an issue — is in the **Appendix**.

Rules & spirit

- There are probably ways to game this, please don't. The point is to learn Grafana and have fun, so stay in the spirit of the event.

- **Alerts aren't your oracle:** no alarms or thresholds have been tuned for this event. Some alerts may fire when an issue is triggered and some won't — and a pre-existing warning doesn't mean it's the issue you're looking for.
- **Grafana Assistant (AI) and gcx CLI access are disabled** on purpose — so you get hands-on with the platform itself.
- **Shared instance:** everyone is on the same Grafana. Anything you create (dashboards, etc.) is visible to everyone else, so be considerate and respectful of what you and others are creating.

FAQ

What does a flag look like, and where do they hide?

Flags look like `EFTSURE_FLAG{...}` — for example `EFTSURE_FLAG{example_3f9k2}`. Each one is a deliberate string planted in the broken service's telemetry. Some examples of places a flag could hide:

- **Logs** — in a log line or a log field.
- **Metrics** — as a label value on a metric.
- **Traces** — as an attribute on a span.

Some only appear once a problem is **severe** (a threshold crossed) or **intermittently** (only on some requests), so keep looking even if the first place you check is empty.

What do I do once I find a flag?

DM **Scotty** with three things:

- the **flag value** (`EFTSURE_FLAG{...}`)
- a **screenshot** of where you found it
- your **team name**

Found it early? Use the time to get more familiar with the platform and set yourself up for a future flag, or keep an eye out for other flags that might already be in action.

How does scoring work?

When an issue is triggered, a **30-minute clock** starts for that flag. Your score is the number of **minutes remaining** when you submit it correctly — find it 1 minute in and you score ~29; find it 29 minutes in and you score 1; miss it within 30 minutes and it's 0. The cadence is loose: a new issue may start before the previous one is found, and a couple may run at once — each flag has its own clock from the moment it was triggered.

How do teams and prizes work?

You'll play in **teams of 2–3**. Points add up across all the flags you find through the day, and the **team with the most points at the end of the day wins**.

Which services can (and can't) have issues?

Issues never come from the support/infrastructure services — `frontend-proxy`, `otel-collector`, `telemetry-docs`, `flagd`, `flagd-ui`, `load-generator` — nor from Kafka, Accounting or Fraud Detection (not running this event). Any other application service is fair game; see the Appendix for the full list and which ones could surface an issue.

Where do I go?

- Grafana (hunt for flags here): https://hackathon.grafana.net

- The demo app (browse the store): http://grafana-hackathon.in.eftsure.com
- Scoreboard (live standings): https://scoreleader.com/u/33BHFQO

What if I get stuck?

Keep an eye on the **meeting chat** — we'll post periodic messages there as each issue is released (though not immediately, so it pays to stay proactive). If you have any questions or concerns at any point, reach out in the main room or to a facilitator and we'll get someone to support you.

Appendix — Services in the demo

"Could surface an issue?" tells you the *universe* of possible sources — not which are actually live right now (that's the hunt).

Service	What it does	Could surface an issue?
frontend	Web storefront UI and its API (Next.js / TypeScript)	**Yes**
ad	Serves contextual ads on product pages (Java)	**Yes**
cart	Holds each user's shopping cart, backed by the Valkey cache (.NET)	**Yes**
checkout	Orchestrates placing an order; calls payment, shipping, email, cart (Go)	**Yes**
currency	Converts prices between currencies (C++)	**Yes**
payment	Charges the credit card for an order (Node.js)	**Yes**
shipping	Calculates shipping cost and tracking; calls quote (Rust)	**Yes**
quote	Computes a shipping-cost quote (PHP)	**Yes**
email	Sends the order-confirmation email (Ruby)	**Yes**
product-catalog	Product listings, details and search, backed by PostgreSQL (Go)	**Yes**
recommendation	Suggests products based on the cart (Python)	**Yes**
product-reviews	Generates and serves product reviews (uses the LLM service)	**Yes**
llm	Local language-model service used for review summaries	**Yes**
image-provider	Serves product images (nginx)	**Yes**
frontend-proxy	Envoy edge proxy; the entry point routing all traffic	No
flagd	The feature-flag service used to trigger the issues	No
flagd-ui	Web UI for toggling feature flags	No
load-generator	Drives synthetic shopper traffic so there's always activity	No
otel-collector	Receives, processes and ships all telemetry to Grafana Cloud	No
telemetry-docs	Auto-generated documentation of the demo's telemetry	No
cache (Valkey)	Redis-compatible cache backing the cart	No
database (PostgreSQL)	Product-catalog data store	No